

# A Labour of their Love

The Sania-Shoaib liaison has sparked off a battle between the media in Pakistan and India

The debate-triggering Sania-Shoaib match has led to much noise in both Indian and Pakistani media. As if the media on both sides was not bad enough, in steps Firdous Ashiq Awan, Pakistan's federal minister for population welfare, Awan *sahiba* saying that the nation would not leave the cricket star alone in this hour of crisis. If this wasn't enough, the women's wing of the Muslim League (N) hit the streets protesting against "*muhabbat ke dushman* (enemies of love)" in India.

Some Pakistanis, however, were on Mirza's side. A lengthy column by humourist Masood Hasan in *The News* lamented, "Poor Sania. What has her heart done to her head? From the toast of India to the breadcrumb of Dubai?"

The cyberspace has had to endure the Shoaib-Sania noise pollution as well. Pakistan's leading *Jang* Group had created a separate Live section on its web edition branding the duo's decision to marry as "cricket weds tennis" that would "bring a new hope for peace" between the two nuclear neighbours.

The hour of personal crisis has compelled many to recall some legendary love stories. Celebrated *Dawn* columnist and its Delhi-based correspondent Jawed Naqvi says, "True love has always terrorised conservative societies. The legends of Heer and Juliet and their ill-fated suitors have spawned a gamut of narratives in diverse cultures."

The Urdu press at home, however, has had a mixed response. *Siasat*, a leading Urdu daily of Hyderabad, carried a story

quoting former secretary of Andhra Pradesh Cricket Association V. Chamundeswaranath, "The Mirzas want the wedding to take place in a much better mood and frame of mind." Ironically, he faced allegations of misuse of funds and harassing women crick-



## MALIK CLAIMED THAT AYESHA'S FAMILY PRESSURED HIM INTO THE MARRIAGE AND REALISED HE'D BEEN CHEATED AFTER THREE YEARS.

eters. Urdu daily *Sahafat* was angry over the "nonsensical" hype generated by the electronic media. "It has once again displayed its mental bankruptcy," it lamented. *Urdu Sahara* rubbished the media too. It seems, the paper said, there was no burning issue in the sub-continent other than this wedding. *Jadeed Markaz*, a Urdu-Hindi weekly published from Lucknow and Mumbai, pointed out that the people of Pakistan were celebrating as if Malik had conquered Jammu and Kashmir, **by Farzand Ahmed**

fatwa way back in 1975 terming phone marriages invalid after the Andhra Pradesh Wakf Board approached it following the ruckus over such marriages turning sour. Since then the authorities insist on a power of attorney before validating the marriages and issuing certificates.

Still a *nikah* on phone is not uncommon. This happens often as the families involved live in different countries. It may not be a valid marriage contract, but it is validated later when the bridegroom, bride and the witnesses are present at one place.

Though neither the state Govern-

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ment nor the state Wakf board has framed any rules about marriages of local brides and foreign bridegrooms, they have issued oral guidelines. Qazis now want a no-objection certificate from the government of a foreign national and insist that the bridegroom deposit his passport in advance so that it can be verified.

The worst is far from over. Even as the drama rolls on, the Siddiquis and Mirzas of Hyderabad along with the Maliks of Pakistan have spawned a potential cross-border tragicomedy. Bollywood script writers should not let this one pass. **with inputs from Sharda Ugra**